

ALL ORGANISMS ARE POTENTIAL SOURCES OF FOOD FOR OTHER ORGANISMS

THE ECOSYSTEM

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Arthur Tansley (1871–1955)

BEFORE

1864 George Perkins Marsh, an American conservationist, publishes *Man and Nature*, which hints at the concept of ecosystems.

1875 Austrian geologist Eduard Suess proposes the term “biosphere.”

AFTER

1953 American ecologists Howard and Eugene Odum develop a “systems approach” to studying the flow of energy through ecosystems.

1956 American ecologist Paul Sears highlights the role of ecosystems in recycling nutrients.

1970 Paul Ehrlich and Rosa Weigert warn of potentially destructive human interference in ecosystems.

British biologist Arthur Tansley was the first to insist that communities of organisms in a particular area had to be seen in a wider context, including the nonliving elements of that area. Tansley argued that in a given region, all the living organisms and their geophysical environment together form a